

products and reduce dependence on imports. Large-scale clusters for vegetable production will be developed closer to major consumption centres and farmer-producer start-ups will be promoted for collection, storage and marketing.

The transition towards green energy has taken root in India and a road map is being formulated for moving industries from energy efficiency targets to lower emission targets. Appropriate regulations for

industry, women-specific skilling programmes are to be organised, apart from providing market access to women owned enterprises.

On the tax front, the Finance Minister has announced that there would be a comprehensive review of the Income Tax Act, 1961, with a view to make it concise, lucid and devoid of ambiguities which would reduce litigation. Apart from announcing the revival of the scheme for resolving pending disputes,

the scope of safe harbour rules are steps in the right direction that would make India one of the most favourable investment destinations in the world.

Measures like rationalising the personal income tax rates would enhance disposable income for middle class citizens. The capital market has taken in its stride the rationalisation of short-term and long-term capital gains tax rates as well as the increase in the securities transaction tax for securities derivative trading. The change in the customs duty structure will facilitate domestic manufacturing, promote exports, reduce prices for cancer drugs and mitigate disputes with the department.

The Budget presents a well-defined strategy that balances multiple objectives of reducing fiscal deficit as well as government debt while sustaining robust public investment in critical sectors of the Indian economy. International credit rating agencies are bound to take cognisance of the strong fiscal foundation that is sought to be laid, while fostering sustainable growth with massive capital investment.

A solid foundation has been laid based on the trinity of fiscal prudence, public investment, and inclusive growth. This multi-dimensional approach adopted by the Finance Minister will enable India to meet the challenges of the current fragile global economic environment. It is internationally recognised that India is the bright star on the horizon, and it will march forward with renewed vigour on its path to becoming a developed nation and the third-largest economy in the world by 2030. **BT**

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Views are personal*



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transition of industries to the 'Indian Carbon Market' mode are to be put in place. Financial assistance is to be provided to MSMEs for shifting them to cleaner forms of energy.

The Budget proposals deal with diverse areas from space economy to the development of spiritual tourism. Empowering women has always been the focus of the government and several reforms have been announced for women backed up by an allocation of almost ₹3 lakh crore. In collaboration with

the period for reopening past assessments has been drastically curtailed, which would bring some finality to past assessments within a period of five years.

Foreign companies that are planning to invest in India will be considerably benefitted with the reduction of the tax rate from 40% to 35%. Simplification of foreign direct investment rules would ensure further inflows of direct investment into the country. Withdrawal of the 2% equalisation levy and expanding